ONE-OFF SHIURIM

How Do Miracles Work?

Derech Hashem 2:5:6

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 5, paragraph 6, and Chapter 6, paragraphs 1-2 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 12 July 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: a chain of agents

The Rabbi recalled the previous classes. When the Torah says that Hashem "looks," it means He now turns His attention to judge and implement the results of people's actions. His influence always reaches the world through a chain of agents, never directly, because direct contact would be too intense. When two forces conflict, Hashem does not cancel one; He lets one override the other. On a stormy day, the sar of the wind overrides the sar of the tree.

This also explains the idea of manipulating the structures of the world through Kabbalah. But only Hashem sees the whole picture. A human being, however great, sees from his own small perspective, and tampering may bring good results in the short term and devastating ones in the long run.

Paragraph 6: the Ramhal on miracles

If Hashem is above the whole system, it seems He can stop any part of it whenever He wishes. The Ramhal says exactly this: because Hashem is the overriding power behind the entire system, and constantly sustains it, He can change the natural order whenever He chooses. If He had made the system and left it, He could not; but since He is always at the top and always giving influence, He can at any moment say "stop." That is a miracle. He performs wonders as He wishes, according to need.

The difficulty: conditions made at creation

The problem is that Hazal seem to say otherwise. They teach that when Hashem created the works of the six days He made conditions (tenaim) with them, for example with the sea, that it would split before Israel. Why would He need to? He is in charge of the system and could stop the sea at any time.

The Ramhal answers that of course Hashem can stop anything whenever He wishes. But at creation He showed every element of creation its essence, the purpose for which it was made, and its ultimate destiny, and they all recognised that everything is directed towards the ultimate good and rejoiced. This is what Hazal mean elsewhere when they say that creation

was made with its own consent. Part of what He showed them is that sometimes they would have to change. So the condition with the sea was not "in 2,448 years, on such a day at such an hour, you must stop." It was: know that part of your purpose is that at times I will change you, when I decide.

The Rabbi explained that the Ramhal could not accept the alternative, a God who programmed everything in six days and then simply watches, because that makes Him too detached. So the Ramhal had to adjust the plain meaning of Hazal's statement slightly.

The Rambam: everything set up in advance

The other approach is the Rambam's in Moreh Nevuchim, which takes Hazal literally: every miracle that ever happened or will happen was built into creation during the first six days. "It's like you're programming a robot," set to do something in three weeks' time when you are on holiday. A participant asked how this fits with free will. The Rabbi said it is the same question as Hashem's knowledge and free will in general: somehow it is all set in place, and somehow we are still free.

The Rabbi gave an example of the Rambam's naturalism: Bilam's donkey never spoke; the Rambam writes plainly that it happened in Bilam's prophetic vision, and he treats the angels who came to Avraham in Vayera the same way. The Rabbi attributed this to the Rambam's Aristotelian influence. He also mentioned Shadal (Rabbi Shmuel David Luzzatto), another Italian Luzzatto, no relation, who was unhappy with the Rambam's reading but also perplexed by a talking donkey. He understood it as the donkey braying in a particular way, which Bilam, who had ridden it for years, understood. Just as people understand their dog's barks, Bilam knew his donkey intimately, which the Rabbi suggested is the meaning of Hazal's remark on his closeness to it.

How the change happens

The Ramhal adds that every change begins above, in the upper roots, and comes down through the chain until it is fixed in the physical world. When Hashem decrees, He does not decree on the sea itself but on the agents responsible for it, and they suspend their normal function. When the sun stood still for Yehoshua, according to the Ramhal, Hashem commanded the agents over the sun at that moment to stop; according to the Rambam, it was part of the sun's essence from creation that on that day it would stop.

The main takeaway of the chapter: Hashem is constantly in charge. Despite the agents and the chain, even miracles come from Him. According to the Rambam it is slightly more detached, in that everything was preordained.

Chapter 6: a heavenly court

Chapter 6 deals with the order of hashgahah, the system Hashem set up, and the Rabbi said it will help us understand Rosh Hashanah. Paying attention to something is not the same as judging it: one can watch everything with hawk eyes and never issue a verdict. The Ramhal teaches that as a result of Hashem's attention, judgements are happening all the time, through a judicial system that mirrors the human one, as Hazal say, the court above is like the court below.

Hashem arranged that His leadership of the world, both the consequences of human actions and whether things in the world should change, operates like the courts down here, with all their laws. A participant asked whether it should not be the other way round, that human courts copy the heavenly one. The Rabbi said no: Hashem knew from the beginning how humanity would conduct itself, with courts, prosecutors, defenders and judges at different levels, and set up the heavenly system in the same way. There are higher and lower courts, like a supreme court, and everything is decreed through them. Judgement, in life or after death, is not "just you and God"; it happens in a spiritual courtroom. Here too we will come to understand the Satan and his role.

Why consult?

Why would Hashem need a court at all? A participant compared it to work: gathering information is one thing, acting on it another. The Rabbi said a good leader does not act alone; he consults and hears different angles. Another participant said a good CEO keeps quiet, lets people give their views, and then decides. The Rabbi linked this to "Let us make man," which Hazal explain was said to teach that one should always consult.

Hashem is present in all these courts even if He is not the one judging, just as every beit din knows "Elohim nisav baadat El" and prays at the start of a sitting that Hashem be with it. As the prophet saw: Hashem sitting on His throne, with all the host of heaven to His right and to His left, some prosecuting and some defending. To be continued after the summer break.

Summary

- Paragraph 6: because Hashem constantly sustains the system, He can suspend any part of it at any moment; that is a miracle.
- The Ramhal reads Hazal's "conditions with the sea" as Hashem telling creation that its purpose includes being changed when He decides.
- The Rambam takes the conditions literally: every miracle was programmed into creation in the six days.
- Changes begin in the upper roots and are carried out by the agents over each part of nature.
- Chapter 6: Hashem's oversight works through a heavenly court modelled on human courts, teaching us to consult before deciding.

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